CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

IT SUPPORT SPECIALIST IN THE AI ERA

Every career in tech starts somewhere — this is the somewhere with the lowest door and the most people yelling politely for help.

★ TL;DR — Median around $45K — the honest price of the easiest door in tech — reachable in a 6–12 month band, people-facing and increasingly remote. The catch: it's a launchpad, not a destination; the money is in what you do next. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

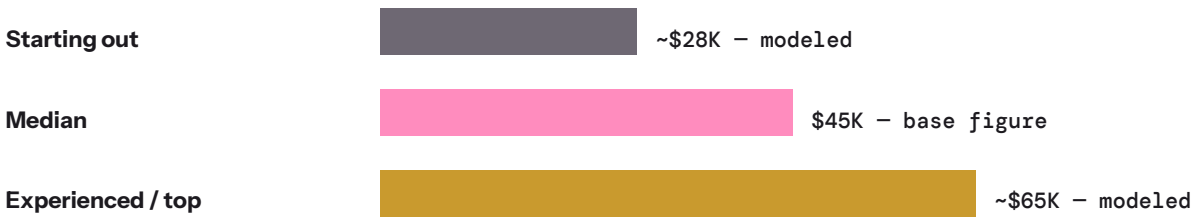
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

- IT support is the classic first rung: low gate, real paycheck, and a map of every other tech job from inside.
- Certifications genuinely matter here — they're how hiring managers sort the pile.
- AI handles the password-reset tier now; troubleshooting judgment and people skills are the human residue.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for IT Support Specialist is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A IT SUPPORT SPECIALIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Answer tickets, calls and chats from employees who can't work
- ✓ Fix account, software, hardware and network problems — or escalate them properly
- ✓ Set up laptops, accounts and access for new hires
- ✓ Document fixes so the next person solves it in minutes

Think: the ER front desk of a company's technology — triage, quick fixes, and knowing which specialist to call.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI chatbots now resolve the routine tier: password resets, VPN basics, how-do-I questions. Ticket deflection is eating the simplest third of the queue.	The weird intermittent failure, the panicking executive before a board meeting, the problem that's actually three problems. Empathy plus diagnosis stays human.

⚠ **Staying at the help desk is the trap — pay plateaus fast. Enter with an exit plan toward systems, cloud or security from month one.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The lowest-friction first tech paycheck ✓ Every day teaches how companies actually run ✓ People-facing work — you're visibly the hero several times a week	✗ Angry users whose emergency is your routine ✗ Metrics on ticket counts that reward speed over care ✗ The pay ceiling arrives quickly if you coast

Good fit? You're patient, methodical and good with frustrated people — and you want a tech career starting this year, not in three years.
Bad fit? You want deep focus work without interruption, or people in a panic drain you.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — CERTIFICATE TO HELP DESK	DOOR B — CUSTOMER SUPPORT SIDEWAYS
Earn the standard entry IT certificate employers filter for, build basic home-lab reps, and apply broadly. In this field the certificate is a genuine screening credential, not decoration.	Already in customer service or retail? Tech companies hire support agents with people skills and train the tech. Your call-center years count here more than anywhere else in tech.

Smart move: Treat the help desk as paid research: log the 20 most common problems in your first months and automate or document three of them. That portfolio is your promotion application.
Where you land after: Systems administrator → cloud, DevOps or cybersecurity — the launchpad works if you actually launch.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
ENTRY CERTIFICATE	HOME LAB	TICKET-CRAF	APPLY WIDE	FIRST SEAT,	AIM THE

STEP 1 — Entry certificate track

$200-400 · MONTHS 1-3

- Study for the standard entry-level IT certification — it's the filter for first interviews.
- Hardware, operating systems, troubleshooting method — the exam syllabus is the job syllabus.

STEP 2 — Home lab reps

FREE · MONTHS 1-3

- Virtual machines: break Windows and Linux on purpose, then fix them.
- Practice account management, permissions and basic networking.

STEP 3 — Ticket-craft

FREE · MONTHS 2-4

- Learn how support teams work: ticketing systems, SLAs, escalation etiquette.
- Write mock tickets for your lab problems — documentation is half the job.

STEP 4 — Apply wide

MONTHS 3-6

- Help desk, IT support, desktop support, tech support — apply to all of them.
- Tailor to the posting's stack: Microsoft shops, Google shops and Mac shops differ.

STEP 5 — First seat, learn the map

MONTHS 4-9

- In the job, master the top recurring issues and the escalation paths.
- Start your exit-lane study (cloud, systems or security) in parallel, one hour a day.

STEP 6 — Aim the next rung

MONTHS 8-12

- Pick the next certification for your chosen lane.
- Volunteer for the projects — migrations, rollouts — that read as next-level work.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: enroll in the entry certificate course and set up your first virtual machine.
- □ Days 1–30: hardware and OS fundamentals; five lab problems broken and fixed, documented.
- □ Days 31–60: certificate study deepens; ticketing practice; resume rebuilt around labs and certs.
- □ Days 61–90: certificate exam passed or scheduled; applications out in volume.
- □ Day 90: credential in hand (or imminent), a lab portfolio, and interviews in motion.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ FIRST RUNG. NOT THE LAST ONE. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.